



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 35

NEW YORK

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside New York's family courts and child-welfare system.

83

NEW YORK FAMILIES ON RECORD ·
115 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 18
MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF
PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 5, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

31 OF 62

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

NEW YORK AT A GLANCE.

Across 83 New York families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 115 81 of 83 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$165,000 median across 29 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 18 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 43.4% 32.5% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 83	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.4	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 81 of 83	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 31

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so New York families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF NEW YORK FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	45	\$25,000	\$43,887	\$1,974,900
Lost Wages	43	\$18,500	\$83,086	\$3,572,699
Other Court Fees	24	\$0	\$4,967	\$119,200
Therapy / Evaluations	36	\$500	\$4,559	\$164,109
Reunification Services	28	\$0	\$3,712	\$103,950
GAL Fees	23	\$0	\$6,522	\$150,000
Asset Loss ¹	38	\$33,000	—	—
Median Family Burden (29 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$165,000	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$33,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		18	1.5 yrs
Mean months lost		35	2.9 yrs
Total across all families		1,918	159.8 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · NEW YORK

Most families documenting in New York are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		33	40%
Not provided		26	31%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		10	12%
Case closed: within last 2 years		7	8%
Not in court but still affected		3	4%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		40	48%
Family Court Only		23	28%
Unknown		16	19%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		2	2%
Family Court		1	1%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		18	22%
3 – 5 years		16	19%
5 – 10 years		11	13%
Over 10 years		10	12%
6 months – 1 year		7	8%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		23	28%
50/50 Joint		21	25%
Visitation Only		18	22%
Full Custody		7	8%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		4	5%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Erie		8	10%
Suffolk		5	6%
Ulster		3	4%
Genesee		3	4%
Westchester		3	4%
Queens		2	2%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		26	31%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		13	16%
High Conflict Divorce		8	10%
Family Court		7	8%
Other: (Short answer)		6	7%

04 PARENT VOICES — NEW YORK

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable New York comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



The child trafficking industry has ruined my life & my Special needs son landins life our family's life. Idk if we will fully heal from this trauma. We will work on it. As soon as we're allowed to. When landin is home. But until then. U cant heal in forced daily trauma & thats [...]

— JODI

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

My kids SA abuse was not handled properly by CPS or investigated properly with the police, and intern it used against myself and my wife. It was said to be a false allegation, even though it came out of the mouth of our children, and they took their therapist. Their therapist [...]

— NEW YORK PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM NEW YORK

The system is beyond corrupted. It has caused nothing but trauma and devastation to me and the children.

— ANTONINA (ANTONELLA)

Has caused unfixable trauma to myself and my children. My 3 yr old has developed a blinking tick. He's had a complete behavioral change, sad crying saying no more daddy house. My one yr old is behind for talking, obsessive sucking of thumb. My 6 yr old foster son who I've had [...]

— MERRISA

My children's father has abused the kids and admittedly uses drugs, has abused and killed family pets, attempted to kill us, stalked me for years and my older children and now has sol custody due to court influences. I (mom) do not smoke, drink, or use drugs, I run an [...]

— NICOLE

Removed my children from me violated my rights to parent.

— SHAWN

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



This court ignored facts, perpetuated FRAUD, conspired to deprive me and my children of life, liberty, justice and our assets, while the stalking and abuse continue.

— CINDI

2 petitions back to back with false allegations and a motion with 16 pages of false allegations and a cps report with false allegations and a call to my employer with false allegations....stolen time for my daughter and my relationship

— JASON

My ex and his attorney submitted false documentation to the court. The judge refused to allow my attorney to speak, while allowed my ex's attorney to speak at length, which set the tone. Marriage was clearly one sided and full of emotional and mental abuse. I am being forced to [...]

— OLIVIA

Has allowed a child abusing mother that was confirmed by CPS multiple times to continue to abuse and neglect the children to the point of illiteracy. Although court ordered 50/50 custody and every other week visitation I have not seen the children in almost 8 years and I've paid [...]

— WILLIAM

The court placed my now adult twin daughters with a known domestic abuser/sexual predator, leaving them at increased risk of harm, trauma, and poverty. I am being punished with false accusations because I dared speak about my trauma.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It broke me and destroyed my family. I went from being Mom of the year to feeling like a stranger.

— D.

Furthered the abuse and harm we were already facing. When the victims assistance center finally picked us up the night they took us to shelter I remember bawling my eyes out. At that point I had lost hope that there was any real chance at getting out of what we were living [...]

— LEEAH

Ruined it. My kids cry for me, my ex lied, had admitted it and the courts do not care. Lost everything at one point and there is 0 evidence except he said she said.

— AMANDA

Destroyed my family life & friendships. Left me homeless

— ANTONY

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



My abuser has been coddled and has been allowed to abuse me through the family court system not just me both my kid's as well.

— CRYSTAL

Cps has told the school not to release my kids to me on my court order parenting days despite doing everything they asked My ex is also telling my kids the state said there not allowed on my property.

— HEATHER M

My soon to be 6 year old son is being unlawfully concealed by a corrupt abuse of power within the Onondaga County NYS Family Court. The other party is related to local police. A preschool is also being investigated affiliated with my custody case.

— ASHLEY

The system destroyed my family

— SHELBY

This court has ruined my children's future for their own personal gains

— HAL

They have made my other children hate me and are trying to take my child away now they have caused my family to have to live in fear

— MARGARET

Took my daughter away from me for 30 months when she was only 6 yrs old and she is now 9. A new referee presided over my case and my daughter was finally returned home October 2025, and we are still struggling to repair the damage that family court and CPS has done.

— ALYSSA

I was the only one caring and doing everything for my kids but they were ripped from me and it messed with them tremendously. My 10 yr old did not but cry my 4 yr old almost forgot who I was and I had no bond to my 3 month old.

— KIM

It has broken my family apart, cause immense psychological damage to my children, and forced me to close my business after 34 years

— STEVEN

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



My family was broken and financially devastated. I will never be able to recover because I am now paying my abuser

— MARK

The system that was meant to protect my children instead replaced their voices with a verdict, separating them from their only advocate and allowing harm to echo where protection should have stood. Protection without accountability is not protection.

— MCKALEA

It was traumatized my daughter and I, and has continued to have a negative impact on my life. After removing my daughter and placing her with her father-KNOWING HE HAS A HISTOY OF ABUSE & ORDERS OF PROTECTIONS AGAINST for my daughter and I, not long after my daughter was [...]

— RACHEL

They triggered my kids mental health purposely to make her unstable causing a mental health crisis that was turned around on me to take the blame. Lost housing services. My children were groomed into fearing me. loss of \$10k in personal belongings that was left behind

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They wanna press charges if my daughter doesn't go again to school because she was threatened by a student there if she near him he will do something bad and she is scared for her life to go back she feels unsafe and she showed the CPS evidence and they didn't care that she [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I have had a major part of who I am torn from me. The system stole my 5 kids. 14 years since I have struggled with this. I've been lost with no purpose. I wish someone would stop them from destroying families just for their gain.

— STACEY

Bias. Never was questioned before about parenting and i was the primary caregiver. I was the favorite parent and he hated it (hates it)

— SAMANTHA

This system has caused irreparable damage to my children and I. Their lives have been negatively impacted due to the inability of the system to function properly!

— MEAGHAN

This system took so much time and the most formative years with my daughter from me. Time neither her or I will ever get back.

— NICOLE

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Failed me and said they were doing it as the child's best interest but all I saw was a greedy system with an agenda

— CRISTIAN

Destroyed my faith in the system and greatly affected the relationship with my son for no good reason other than for money in someone else's pocket without fair due process

— JESSICA

Allow my constitutional rights be violated while allowing an unstable mother have temporary custody and ignoring all the fact stating wait until trial.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The family court system used fraud and bullying tactics to separate me for my children where I was a primary custodial caretaker for 3 1/2 years. They did this in an effort to solely get my ex-wife child support and payments, regardless of the fact that her situation was [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Was never told what allegations were, was drug into court and threatened by my own attorney to give up the children. No paperwork was ever provided until a week after being taken into court. My 18 month old granddaughter nearly died from a broken heart and my 4 year old [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The family court system deprived me of my life, liberty and the pursuit of happiness. I never thought I would experience grieving the loss of my children while knowing they're still alive and being abused on a daily basis without being able to heal and live a normal childhood. [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

All involved have intentionally caused verbal, emotional, psychological trauma by taking extreme measures. My son showing, screaming crying he did not want to go with his father and sleepovers happened within 2 visits later. His dad was missing for 4 years and Referee didn't [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This happened to me 16 to 17 years ago I don't remember much, I reconnected with my son once he turned 13

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The antiquated family court system is one of my initiatives for running for House of Representatives. I know god has handled my cases but I know that god appears to be missing from many.

— JESSICA

49 New York parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 42 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — NEW YORK

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from New York families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

The child trafficking industry has ruined my life & my Special needs son landins life our family's life. Idk if we will fully heal from this trauma. We will work on it. As soon as we're allowed to. When landin is home. But until then. U cant heal in forced daily trauma & thats what this is. You're grieving daily for your alive child. That's begging to come home. Yet their Captors won't let them. This evil has destroyed my body. From the stress of this case. They took my childhood home. They gave me cancer. Thankfully I cured in time. They forced me to pay for parenting course that they didn't pay me back for. I had to use my ssi money to print out court paperwork. This case cost me A lot of money. That I don't Have the receipts for. I was A victim of an arson fire. That took my childhood Home from me. If this Evil never trafficked my Son. My home wouldn't Have burnt to the ground. This evil took yrs. That I Can't get back with my Son. Milestones that I can't get back. My first born. Only son Currently. Idk if I'll have anymore kids. This evil has Stolen my joy & will to want To live. I live To see my Son returned Home safely & to heal With him. This evil Has made My heart My life Be snuffed Out & turn Black as Cole. I pray when the lord of vengeance comes back & ends this evil for Good & they suffer in hell. Forever. That's my joy. I look forward to.

— JODI

The system is beyond corrupted. It has caused nothing but trauma and devastation to me and the children.

— ANTONINA (ANTONELLA)

My kids SA abuse was not handled properly by CPS or investigated properly with the police, and intern it used against myself and my wife. It was said to be a false allegation, even though it came out of the mouth of our children, and they took their therapist. Their therapist are the ones who hotlined it. They have never gotten justice they fear people who should help them. Their sister was just taking away for the second time with no evidence whatsoever. I've been with my wife for six years. She's been going through this longer, but every day is dreading the next court date.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Has caused unfixable trauma to myself and my children. My 3 yr old has developed a blinking tick. He's had a complete behavioral change, sad crying saying no more daddy house. My one yr old is behind for talking, obsessive sucking of thumb. My 6 yr old foster son who I've had since birth my have been sexually abused and cps refused to take him to the emergency room when he said it hurt up inside him

— MERRISA

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

My children's father has abused the kids and admittedly uses drugs, has abused and killed family pets, attempted to kill us, stalked me for years and my older children and now has sole custody due to court influences. I (mom) do not smoke, drink, or use drugs, I run an animal rescue and my own business as well as volunteer time for special education programs. I homeschool my oldest daughter's who are well rounded and amazing young lady's. I now can't see my children and am constantly being dragged into false allegations court cases and draining any income I have coming in.

— NICOLE

Removed my children from me violated my rights to parent.

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This court ignored facts, perpetuated FRAUD, conspired to deprive me and my children of life, liberty, justice and our assets, while the stalking and abuse continue.

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— JASON

My ex and his attorney submitted false documentation to the court. The judge refused to allow my attorney to speak, while allowed my ex's attorney to speak at length, which set the tone. Marriage was clearly one sided and full of emotional and mental abuse. I am being forced to reside NY, although both our families are in MI. He refuses to comply to our agreement and has taken me back to court where we received a new judge who didn't read any of the paperwork and then we were pushed to dismiss our motions. Daughter's attorney has done absolutely nothing to learn about daughter or hear her out. Daughter is now experiencing the brunt of the abuse and therapist, school admin refuse to help her voice be heard.

— OLIVIA

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Has allowed a child abusing mother that was confirmed by CPS multiple times to continue to abuse and neglect the children to the point of illiteracy. Although court ordered 50/50 custody and every other week visitation I have not seen the children in almost 8 years and I've paid close to 25,000 in child support with no access to my children. And you can quote this "every single person named in the aforementioned documents, you know that I have the proof and you know I'm right and what you've done..."

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Furthered the abuse and harm we were already facing. When the victims assistance center finally picked us up the night they took us to shelter I remember bawling my eyes out. At that point I had lost hope that there was any real chance at getting out of what we were living safely. I never imagined it would end up getting me to safety but putting my kids back into harms way and now in a place where I can't even protect them or explain to them what's happening. I can see the confusion and anger in them and it tears my heart open every visit. In my past I did a lot of wrong and my justice was served. Now I'm a good person with lots of wrong being done and no justice. It's a scary place to be but more horrifying place when you can't protect your children.

— LEEAH

Ruined it. My kids cry for me, my ex lied, had admitted it and the courts do not care. Lost everything at one point and there is 0 evidence except he said she said.

— AMANDA

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— RACHEL

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They wanna press charges if my daughter doesn't go again to school because she was threatened by a student there if she near him he will do something bad and she is scared for her life to go back she feels unsafe and she showed the CPS evidence and they didn't care that she still has to go to school if not I will be arrested knowing I'm a good loving single mother God fearing Christian mother raising my kids beautifully and my daughter loves me to much she has a separation anxiety away from me if she leaves or myself leave she cannot go a day without me the CPS are abusing my story my rights and towards my daughter and use it against me for when they wanna put me in court.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Was never told what allegations were, was dragged into court and threatened by my own attorney to give up the children. No paperwork was ever provided until a week after being taken into court. My 18 month old granddaughter nearly died from a broken heart and my 4 year old granddaughter nearly drowned at her foster house from not being watched. She saved herself because we had taught her early on about swimming and drowning and what to do.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The family court system deprived me of my life, liberty and the pursuit of happiness. I never thought I would experience grieving the loss of my children while knowing they're still alive and being abused on a daily basis without being able to heal and live a normal childhood. Going from tucking them in at night to crying myself to sleep, I am forced to muster up the strength to keep going and I feel as if I'm fighting for my life every single day, this has truly been the most excruciatingly painful thing I could ever imagine, and I would not wish this upon anyone.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

All involved have intentionally caused verbal, emotional, psychological trauma by taking extreme measures. My son showing, screaming crying he did not want to go with his father and sleepovers happened within 2 visits later. His dad was missing for 4 years and Referee didn't tell us about Our Family Wizard until 2024 to coerce me to sign 50/50 custody. Prior the dad was emailing me and then told to use WhatsApp where my offender can see my phone number, he would block my calls not pick up. Whenever I put in a motion, petition the father was granted my time without investigating why Chris refused crying and throwing himself on the floor to now go and spoke it too. The police would never let me do reports from drop offs pick up. My offender has a detective cousin. I placed a complaint in 2020 and this shows retaliation towards my son at child care, at school bullying him, teachers never see anything. I'm blocked from doing police reports or electronically played with on obtaining the reports, Police reports not scanned for Judge or Referee. My son misses me and shows it with school staff, my offender holds the phone and listens, hangs up on me, blocked my calls, didn't answer. Intentional delays, patterns of retaliation, my attorneys not doing their jobs, forcing me to all forms of investigation. Even though, my offender and his sister have shown aggression at police stations and protected by the law because I can not get an order of protection against her.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This happened to me 16 to 17 years ago I don't remember much, I reconnected with my son once he turned 13

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The antiquated family court system is one of my initiatives for running for House of Representatives. I know God has handled my cases but I know that God appears to be missing from many.

— JESSICA

Just existing is exhausting... I hide in my basement I don't go anywhere I don't have friends I don't have a job unfortunately just existing is all I can handle right now

— MARGARITA

I've learned it's not Justice, it's "JUST US!"

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

“This system has wrongfully interfered with my life, reputation and family, targeting me through coordinated actions while placing my daughter, Tynylah, connected to Talicia Craig, in harm’s way and beyond my protection.”

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court leveraged my child to financially drain me until I was forced into bankruptcy. I was then told I could not afford the defense to protect my daughter so I had to sign an unfavorable agreement or risk losing my parenting time.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has taken over 25 years the bond between a mother and her child time loss of the connection loss of special events holidays , birthdays graduation ceremonies Mother’s Day and soso much more to meany to write down

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ruined me in my child

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system took a straightforward divorce seeking equal custody and, through a pattern of exclusion, obstruction, and imbalance, deprived me and my child of meaningful time, stability, and our fundamental parent-child relationship. It fractured not only our bond, but also our connection to extended family and critical life milestones during irreplaceable years.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

49 full approved New York comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this New York report comes from New York respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in New York — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 83 New York families reporting here are not the universe of New York families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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